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WITH A 1.6 PER CENT VOTE LOSS COSTING THE PARTY AS MANY AS 44 SEATS IN 2004, THE BJP IS IN A DESPERATE BID TO SHORE UP ALLIANCES.

THE NDA NEEDS LEADERS LIKE NITISH KUMAR AND NARENDRA MODI MORE THAN THEY NEED THE ALLIANCE

least 24 of the 48 seats up for grabs. NCP leader Sharad Pawar remains non-committal but got his supporters to float his name as prime minister. To add pressure on the Congress, SP leader Amar Singh called on Pawar and vowed that they would support each other as prime minister if the need arose. While NCP is willing to wait until after the polls to seriously contest for prime ministership, it is not willing to concede in Maharashtra where it is running a coalition government with Congress. The party wants to stick to the formula worked out in the 2004 Lok Sabha elections when it got 27 of the 48 seats. NCP, however, wants an equal division in addition to bringing in allies like SP. NCP state chief R.R. Patil says, "The parameters of 2004 cannot be used now." NCP also wants an alliance outside with Congress in states like Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Uttarakhand. It is bargaining for 35 seats across India. In Bihar, both Lalu and LJP President Ram Vilas Paswan want to increase their tally. Paswan has four MPs but he demands 16 seats from a possible RJD-LJP-Congress alliance as opposed to the eight that he got last time.

Congress claims it has leaders with national appeal, while the regional parties insist they have leaders who can win and make others win. Says a senior UPA leader, "Let the Congress answer one simple question. Can any of the Congress leaders

ensure more votes and seats than Mulayam, Pawar and Lalu in their states? Can Rahul influence the result of a single seat in Maharashtra or Bihar?" Adds Lalu: "I smell a conspiracy on the part of the national parties to finish smaller parties. No one from the urban ruling elite class wants smaller parties led by backward leaders to rule the country."

The allies' main worry is the irrational arrogance of Congress. An AICC general secretary never misses an opportunity to attack the SP. In Maharashtra, middle level Congress leaders have been encouraged to launch smear campaigns against Pawar. NCP is having parallel talks with Shiv Sena; Mulayam is flirting with Pawar and the Left; JMM is threatening to defeat Congress as Sonia is not endorsing JMM President Shibu Soren as next chief minister; and JD(s) President H.D. Deve Gowda is asking for more as the Congress can't get Karnataka without his support. "Congress is on cloud nine after a little success of UPA Government. It was achieved not on its own but with the help of its allies. They are trying to create a leadership like Indira Gandhi's with all the powers centred around one person," thunders an editorial in the